

ECLIPSE OF THE ALTERNATIVE

As the Opposition gasped for oxygen, the subcontinent's most enduring political dynasty further consolidated its power

By S. Prasannarajan

Isn't the morning waft of the New Year faintly funereal? The embers of 2009 are still there in our memory, but we can't say that this sense of doom in the first hours of the new decade originates from the marketplace. The Masters of the Universe have regained their smile and are back at the top of their game. Thankfully, globalisation didn't go bankrupt. Then, where does it come from, this reminder of mortality that dampens our resolutions and enhances our fears? Its source must be the political arena; look back and we can't miss the carbonised remains of the Alternative. It was the year in which political dissent died, and even in death it was denied any dignity. In the so-called year of revival, the political narrative defied the trend.

Those who refuse to lose their optimism at the sight of multiplying cadavers in the battlefield could argue that there was indeed a revival, embodied by three faces of triumph: Sonia Gandhi, Rahul Gandhi and Manmohan Singh. The Congress revival, to be specific, began more than five years ago when an idea killed itself in the "shining" fallacy of a slogan. In General Election 2009, it was not a story of either revival or resurrection; it was all about retaining the mandate. In Indian politics, preservation of the mandate is a task more arduous than winning it. So it was a revelatory study in contrast: the BJP in 2004 and the Congress in 2009. In the first, almost prehistory now, five years in power, that too with one of India's most indulged and charismatic men at the helm, made the BJP look tired and tiring. It aged prematurely, its mind shrank, and finally, when it just got to know the semantics of power, it lost India.

How did the Congress 2009 avoid the fate of the BJP 2004? Was it that India's natural party of governance knew how not to be waylaid by power? Or was it that the Congress was too seasoned a party, now 125 years old, to be led into the make believe of immortality by the temptations of power? Or, was it that India found the accidental prime minister, and

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